



Free, and Accepted

Two words on every summons

LORE

Two words nobody reads, both doing real historical work: the freedom of an operative craft, and the accepted gentlemen who took the lodges over and never gave them back.

ON THE TABLE

Your own summons



Elias Ashmole by John Riley — After John Riley
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HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:15	Free: three candidates
4:00	Accepted: the more interesting word
6:30	What the "and" is doing
8:15	Why keep saying it
9:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Free carried three meanings: the freestone, the freedom of the guild, and a free man.
- 2 Accepted means the non-operatives admitted from the 1600s — Moray 1641, Ashmole 1646.
- 3 Every man in this room is an accepted mason. Not one of us is free of the craft in the trade sense.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

FREE, AND ACCEPTED



So which meaning of "free" is the right one?

Probably all three, at different periods. The single-answer approach is a Victorian tidy-up.

Who was the first accepted mason?

Unanswerable. The earliest well-documented English admission is Elias Ashmole at Warrington in 1646; Robert Moray at Newcastle in 1641 is earlier and Scottish.

Did operatives and accepted men meet together?

Yes, for a long period. That overlap is exactly how the transition happened.

Why do the Antients' descendants say "Antient Free and Accepted"?

A claim to the older usage, made during the eighteenth-century schism. See Paper Eleven.

SOURCES

- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723
- Elias Ashmole's diary, 16 October 1646 — the Warrington admission
- Knoop & Jones, The Genesis of Freemasonry — the operative-to-speculative transition
- David Stevenson, The Origins of Freemasonry: Scotland's Century 1590–1710 — for Moray and the Scottish evidence

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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